

Eitz Chayim

71a

Version 3

Nissan Blumenthal
Arr. Stuart Izon

The true origins of this setting are murky, and in many scores it is attributed as traditional or ancient melody. Whilst the Blue Book determines this to be a composition by Nissan Blumenthal, it seems rather similar to an earlier melody in use at the Hamburg Temple, which was transcribed in the 1820s by Albert Methfessel and Moses Haarbleicher, and later included in Hirsch Goldberg's "Gesänge für Synagogen". Idelsohn suggests that it may derive even further back from the Sephardi piyut for Tal, "Lech l'shalom geshem", and may have been introduced to the Hamburg Temple by the Portuguese hazzan David Meldola.

Of course the main motif here is the ascending minor scale which is also common to Hatikva and Leoni's Yigdal, and as far as we know, the theme for all of these ultimately derives from La Mantovana, a 16th century song by Giuseppe Cenci – see 65c for a more detailed discussion. In any case the alterations which Blumenthal would have made are not insignificant, and warrant his authorship on this piece.

Complicating things further, this Eitz Chayim is often combined with other melodies. In North America it is very common to switch to an unrelated tune at Hashiveinu (71d). This is most likely due to the popularity of Samuel Malavsky's 1961 album "Sabbath with the Malavsky Family", which similarly marries these two pieces together.

Melody Alto

8

mp

Eitz cha - yim hi la - ma - cha - zi - kim ba v' -

Tenor Bass

5

M A

- to - m' - che - ha m' - u - shar d' -

T B

9

M
A

-ra - - che - ha dar - chei no - am v' -

d' - ra - che - ha dar - chei no - am

T
B

13

M
A

-chol n' - ti - vo - te - ha sha - - lom

T
B

17

C.

Ha - shi - - vei - nu a - do - nai

M
A

p
Ah

T
B

22

C.

ei - - le - cha v' - na - shu - va

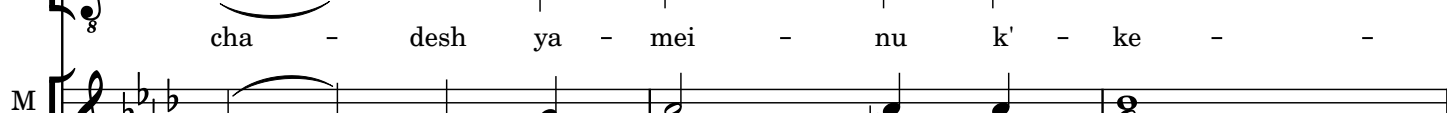
M
A

Ah

T
B

26

C.  cha - desh ya - mei - nu k' - ke -

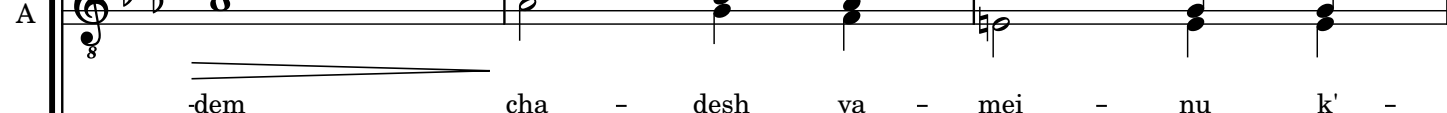
M A  cha - desh ya - mei - nu k' - ke -

T B  cha - desh ya - mei - nu k' - ke -

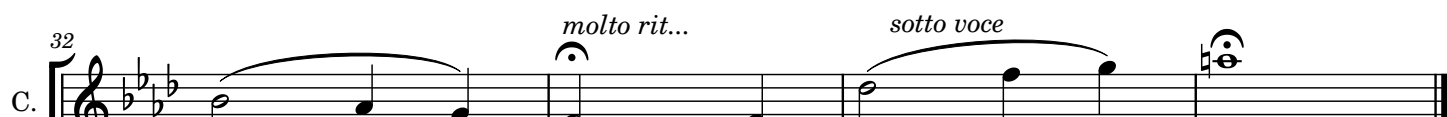
29

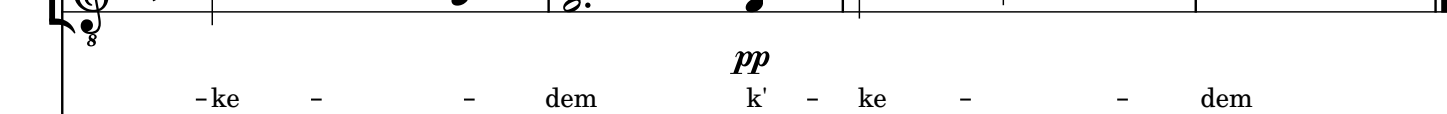
C.  -dem cha - desh ya - mei - nu k' -

M A  -dem cha - desh ya - mei - nu k' -

T B  -dem cha - desh ya - mei - nu k' -

32

C.  -ke - - dem k' - ke - - dem

M A  -ke - - dem k' - ke - - dem

T B  -ke - - dem k' - ke - - dem

molto rit... *sotto voce* *pp*